WAC
Windows Artefacts Collector

CENTRE D'EXCELLENCE CYBERDEFENSE AEROSPATIALE

Created by the Aerospace Cyber Defence Centre of Excellence (CEC)

Against KAPE and EZ

WAC (Windows Artefacts Collector)

Windows artefact collection software for digital forensic investigation



SYSTEM ARTEFACTS

USER FILES

DIGITAL EVIDENCE

A TOOL IN SUPPORT OF DIGITAL INVESTIGATION

WAC — Windows Artefacts Collector

Against KAPE and Eric Zimmerman's tools

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This document confronts WAC with the community's reference tools: KAPE for collection, Eric Zimmerman's command-line tools for decoding. On the same exhibits of the same machine, it compares running times, what each one takes, the accuracy of the values — every difference settled by an independent reference —, the output formats, and the traces each one leaves on the examined machine. It says what the confrontation taught WAC, and what it still holds against it.

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CHAPTER 1

The method

1.1 What is compared

Two questions, two comparisons.

Collection: WAC against KAPE
Both tools collect the same machine one after the other; what each copies is compared, the time it takes, and the SHA-1 of the files both copy.

Traces left: WAC, KAPE and the EZ tools
Each one is started from the same state of the same machine, under Sysmon; what it writes there is recorded, what Windows writes there because of it, and what a monitoring tool sees of it (chapter 5).

Decoding: WAC against the EZ tools
On the *same exhibits* — the exhibit store of a WAC collection —, WAC converts the whole collection and the matching Eric Zimmerman tool decodes, on a copy, the exhibits of its artefact; both outputs are compared record by record and field by field.

1.2 Who is right when they differ

A difference between two tools does not say which one is wrong. Every difference was therefore settled by a third source, independent of both:

- Windows itself: the XML it renders for an event (`Get-WinEvent`), a file's date, the NTFS object identifier (`fsutil objectid`), the live registry, a file's hash (`Get-FileHash`);
- another implementation: `dissect.esedb` (Fox-IT) for ESE databases;
- the format itself: sequence numbers and Marvin32 digests of the hive logs, read byte by byte;
- two artefacts of the same machine cross-checked: Prefetch for execution, a row's timestamp for its other dates.

Each difference is then classed: *defect of WAC* (fixed), *error of the EZ tool* (checked), or *convention* of either — two forms of one value.

1.3 The test bench

Machine	Windows 11 Pro (build 26200), virtual machine
EZ tools	version 2026.5.0 (.NET 9.0.20)
KAPE	version 1.3.0.2, target `KapeTriage`
WAC	version 3.0.0 with the fixes this confrontation brought
Measurements	29 and 30 October 2026
Traces measure	clone of the machine, no network, frozen; Sysmon 15.22; tools on a USB key (K:), one run per tool

Everything can be replayed: `vmtest/ez-compare.sh <artefact>` times the EZ tool on a copy of the exhibits and compares its output with WAC's conversion; `vmtest/lib/timing-table.py` sets the time of each step side by side; `vmtest/kape-compare.sh` does the same for collection; `vmtest/footprint/run-footprint.sh` replays the measure of the traces and `footprint-diff.py` analyses it. The EZ tools ran with their full date precision (`--mp`, or `--dt` with seven decimals where `--mp` is not enough), so as not to blame them for a loss of precision a setting avoids.

CHAPTER 2

Summary

For each artefact, the outputs of WAC and of the EZ tool are paired record by record, then compared field by field. The last column gives each difference found and who is right, established by an independent source (chapter 6); a field not listed there has the same value on both sides.

Artefact — tool	Compared	Fields compared	Differences, and who is right
$MFT — MFTECmd	358,335 records	path, state (deleted, directory), 8 dates, size, MFT entry	sizes of 2,010 compressed files (WOF) and of 10 files open for writing: WAC, as Windows
EVTX — EvtxECmd	246,096 events	identifier, date, provider, machine, event data	25 values: WAC, as Windows; 835 Perflib events EvtxECmd does not read; cleared logs it ignores
Prefetch — PECmd	411 files	executable, hash, runs and their dates, volumes, loaded files	hash without its leading zero in PECmd (20); two volumes' directories run together (1); null volume date written 1601 (2)
Shortcuts — LECmd	67 files	target, dates to 100 ns, size, volume, machine, arguments	none
Jump lists — JLECmd	123 entries	path, counter, pinning, dates, each entry's shortcut	none
Shellbags — SBECmd	46 folders	name, rank, key and folder dates, MFT entry	wrong NodeSlot at first level in SBECmd (9); "explored" always false
Amcache — AmcacheParser	1,890 entries	the 124 shared columns of the 8 tables	5,500 values absent from the hive, invented by AmcacheParser; partial SHA-1 not flagged
ShimCache — AppCompat-CacheParser	596 entries	path, date, rank	none; AppCompatCacheParser's misleading "executed" flag is not reported

Artefact — tool	Compared	Fields compared	Differences, and who is right
Recycle bin — RBCmd	130 files	original path, size, deletion date	none
SRUM — SrumECmd	115,899 rows	the 7 tables, all their columns	8 energy rows shifted by one row in SrumECmd (dissect.esedb)
Registry — RECmd	9 artefacts	UserAssist, BAM, USBSTOR, accounts, Run, MuiCache, typed paths, searches, trusted documents	hives rolled back by RECmd (BAM, UserAssist, USBSTOR, SAM, trusted documents)
Collection — KAPE	1,430 files taken by both	SHA-1 fingerprint	18 different: files Windows rewrote between the two collections

Key point

On everything both sides read, WAC gives the same values as the reference tools, or more accurate ones, each time established by an independent source. The confrontation also revealed 29 defects of WAC, all fixed (chapter 8), and coverage gaps, all filled since (section 6.2).

Started from a key, WAC writes nothing on the examined machine: no file, no registry value, no event in Windows' logs. What remains are the traces Windows leaves of any program started (Amcache, ShimCache), and what a monitoring in place records of its execution: Sysmon, process creation auditing, an EDR; the hives read again offline confirm it. KAPE, a .NET program, writes to the user's registry, and its modules keys in SOFTWARE and files on the system volume (chapter 5).

CHAPTER 3

Running times

3.1 The method

WAC is not measured artefact by artefact. A conversion run for a single artefact makes it pay, each time, what it really pays once: checking the seal and the fingerprints of the exhibit store, rebuilding the working copy, repairing the hives. A collection run for a single artefact makes it open and walk the volume again each time. The times below therefore come from *one* full collection and *one* full conversion. WAC records the time of each of its steps in `investigation.json` and `conversion.json`. Each artefact is set against the EZ tool that decodes it. The steps the other tools do not have are given apart. `vmtest/lib/timing-table.py` puts them side by side.

3.2 Collection

KAPE (target `KapeTriage`) and WAC collect the same machine, one right after the other.

Tool, setting	Time	Files	Volume
KAPE, `KapeTriage`	53 s	1,435	0.98 GB
WAC, without the executables (`binary: none`)	226 s	16,042	7.52 GB
of which the deleted files recovered	156 s	12,529	4.29 GB
WAC, kit as shipped (`binary: unverified`)	626 s	72,188 recorded	8.50 GB

Two thirds of WAC's collection go to the deleted files, which version 3.0.0 recovers by default (level 2, at most 4 GiB copied): KAPE recovers none. Without them, WAC takes in 64 s what KAPE takes in 53 s, and 2,078 files more (3,513 in all, 3.2 GB). Its steps, measured in this run:

WAC step	Time	In KAPE
Checks: rights, free space on the medium	0.00 s	no space check
Observation of the running machine: sessions, processes, network, services, clock	0.15 s	—

WAC step	Time	In KAPE
System hives, raw NTFS reading; the volume is opened once, and its directories cached for the whole collection	2.34 s	copy, raw reading for locked files
User hives	0.25 s	same
Artefact files (logs, Prefetch, shortcuts, browsers, ETW traces, mail…)	38.22 s	same
$MFT, $UsnJrnl, $LogFile, $Boot, $Secure:$SDS	6.63 s	same
Boot sectors and files (MBR, GPT, boot sectors, EFI partition)	2.51 s	—
Search for FAT and exFAT volumes (USB keys) and reading of their metadata	0.04 s	—
Shadow copies, raw reading, without the VSS service (none on the machine)	0.01 s	option, through the VSS service
Resource files of the providers the logs cite, for the events' text	13.76 s	—
Deleted files: content of the free records of the $MFT and names left in the indexes	156.10 s	—
Sealing: manifest, SHA-256 fingerprint of the manifest	0.29 s	copy log
Outside the steps: start-up, writing of the investigation log	4.7 s	

The three fingerprints of each exhibit (MD5, SHA-1, SHA-256) and its NTFS dates are taken during the reading itself: sealing only has to write the manifest. Deleted files aside, the steps of WAC's own — checks, observation of the machine, boot, FAT volumes, shadow copies, providers' resources, sealing — cost 16.8 s, 13.8 s of them for the providers' resources. They are what lets the analysis workstation render every event's text as Windows displays it. The level and budget of the deleted files are set in `wac.yml` (`deleted_files`).

With the executables (the shipped kit's setting), the collection takes 626 s, 334 s of them to read every executable, library, driver and script of the volume. WAC checks their Authenticode signature, in memory, against its trust set, and copies only those whose signature does not hold. The 40,531 files read divide as follows:

- 25,875 authenticated as Microsoft and 329 cleared by a third-party chain: fingerprints recorded, files not copied;
- 11,334 Windows differential files (MSDELTA), which are no executables: fingerprints recorded, not copied;
- 2,768 whose signature does not hold, copied (823 MiB);
- 225 whose content is identical to an exhibit already copied: recorded, pointing to that exhibit, not copied again.

The 41 s of the process observation come, in this setting, from the fingerprints of every loaded module, and the 6 s of the trust set from its loading. KAPE makes none of these

checks: it copies its targets' files without examining them.

3.3 Conversion and decoding

WAC's conversion reads the exhibit store of a collection, on the analysis workstation. Each EZ tool reads a copy of the same exhibits: the tool is timed alone, the copy is not. That copy is no formality. Run on the exhibit store itself, SrumECmd wrote into it (its `JetInit` lays a checkpoint and logs beside the database), and WAC then refused to convert a store that no longer matched its manifest.

Artefact	WAC	WAC `--binary`	EZ tool	Tool
$MFT (C: and G:)	4.81 s	4.68 s	10.0 s	MFTECmd (C: only)
Event logs	15.37 s	16.34 s	33.1 s	EvtxECmd
Prefetch (411)	0.36 s	2.78 s	3.0 s	PECmd
Shortcuts	0.04 s	0.19 s	4.4 s	LECmd
Jump lists	0.04 s	0.44 s	0.8 s	JLECmd
Shellbags	0.02 s	0.04 s	1.0 s	SBECmd
ShimCache	0.00 s	0.32 s	1.5 s	AppCompatCache-Parser
Amcache	0.12 s	11.14 s	0.8 s	AmcacheParser
Recycle bin	0.02 s	0.07 s	0.6 s	RBCmd
SRUM	2.26 s	2.36 s	3.1 s	SrumECmd
Registry (Kroll batch)	0.49 s	2.45 s	15.9 s	RECmd
Sum	23.5 s	40.8 s	74.2 s	the 11 tools

To these steps add those WAC pays once for all the artefacts, and which the EZ tools do not have:

Shared WAC step	Time
Check of the seal and of each exhibit's fingerprints	37.2 s
Rebuilding of the working copy from the exhibit store (5.9 GB, 4.3 GB of them deleted files), each copy checked by its fingerprint	136.8 s
Repair of the working copy's hives (replay of their logs)	0.5 s
The suspect's time zone, code page, profiles and account names	0.0 s
Total	174.5 s

The whole conversion takes 209 s: the 175 s shared, the 23.5 s of the eleven compared artefacts, and 10.8 s for the 45 others, which the EZ tools do not read (deleted files, change journal, scheduled tasks, thumbnail caches, RDP connections, mail, browsers…). The eleven EZ tools take 74 s together, without a working copy or a check of the exhibit store. The deleted files weigh most here: their 4.3 GB are checked and copied as any exhibit.

- Once the working copy is made, each WAC decoding is faster than the matching EZ tool: the hives are read once, for every registry artefact.
- The heaviest step is the working copy. It is the condition of an analysis that never touches the exhibit store, and the EZ tools need the same copy, as SrumECmd showed.
- With `--binary`, WAC fingerprints every file the artefacts cite: +2.4 s for the Prefetch (the loaded libraries), +11.0 s for the Amcache. The EZ tools do not.

3.4 Collection from one same state

Measures of the traces comparison (chapter 5), on 29 and 30 October 2026: every tool starts from the same frozen state of the machine, started from the key; the time is that of the task that starts it, in brackets the one the tool reports.

Tool, setting	Time	Taken	On the key
KAPE, `!SANS_Triage`	167 s (136 s)	2,674 files	2,664 files, 1.33 GB
KAPE, `!SANS_Triage` and `!EZParser` modules	304 s (289 s)	2,673 files, 14 tools	2,717 files, 1.86 GB
EZ tools on the live machine (6 tools)	106 s	$MFT, logs, hives, Prefetch, Amcache, ShimCache	36 CSV, 0.60 GB
WAC, collection (default setting)	927 s (924 s)	19,350 exhibits, 71,249 recorded	22,004 files, 9.84 GB

WAC's collection is the longest because it reads *every* executable of the machine — the conversion will be done elsewhere, and does not know yet which ones the artefacts will cite — and because it recovers the deleted files. It fingerprints the executables, checks their signature and copies only those whose signature does not hold; hence 71,249 exhibits recorded for 19,350 copied. The conversion, on the analysis workstation, reads nothing of the machine again (chapter 5). KAPE copies its targets' files without examining them.

CHAPTER 4

What each one takes

4.1 The same exhibits, different files

Latest comparison, 29 October 2026: KAPE with its `KapeTriage` target, and WAC without the executables (`binary: none`), one right after the other; the files are paired by their original path (WAC's manifest, KAPE's copy log). KAPE takes 1,435 files, WAC 16,040; 1,430 are taken by both.

KAPE takes only 5 files WAC does not: `desktop.ini` files, which only set a folder's icon and display name. WAC takes 14,610 more: the deleted files it recovers (12,529); OneDrive's logs and settings (811); the resource files of the event providers (285), which give the events' text; the ETW traces (227); Defender (186); the boot sectors and files (158); Thunderbird's mail (156); the shortcuts outside Recent (76); the Windows search index and the thumbnail caches (53 in all); other hives and NTFS metadata; DPAPI, the cloud identity, BITS, WMI, hosts, setupapi, the FAT volumes, the running machine's state.

Of the 1,430 shared files, 1,412 have the same SHA-1 fingerprint. The other 18 are files Windows keeps rewriting — $MFT, change journal, Prefetch, Defender's logs, WebCache — and changed between the two collections.

4.2 What is recorded of each exhibit

	WAC (manifest)	**KAPE (copy log)**
Fingerprints	MD5, SHA-1, SHA-256	SHA-1
File dates	the 4 of `$STANDARD_INFORMATION` and the 4 of `$FILE_NAME`, to the 100 ns, in UTC and in the suspect's local time	3 of `$STANDARD_INFORMATION` (creation, modification, access), to the 100 ns, in UTC, without the MFT record change
Location	MFT record number	path alone
Method	stated for every exhibit (raw NTFS reading, live observation)	ordinary copy; "deferred" raw reading for locked files (180 out of 2,674)
Failure	code and cause in the manifest, exhibit by exhibit	console and log

	WAC (manifest)	KAPE (copy log)
Integrity	sealed manifest (SHA-256), checked again at every conversion	—

> **Key point**
> The `$FILE_NAME` dates are those an intruder does not rewrite with the ordinary functions: a backdated file (“timestomping”) keeps its real creation date in `$FILE_NAME`. KAPE’s log does not have them; WAC’s manifest gives them for every exhibit, with the MFT record that finds it again in `mft.json`.

CHAPTER 5

Traces left on the examined machine

5.1 The measure

A clone of the test machine, without network, is frozen with Sysmon 15.22 installed; the tools are on a USB key, drive K:. Every run starts from that same state: the system disk and the key are fresh layers over the frozen images. Once the boot is over, each tool is started the same way — a scheduled task of the user, with its elevated rights, as an examiner from an elevated prompt.

The files
The USN number of C:'s change journal is read just before and just after the tool: any file created, modified, renamed or deleted between the two is in it, even one created then deleted during the run. The readings are written to the key, after the end bound.

The author
Sysmon gives the tool's process tree and what each process wrote, files and registry, and each process it opened. A write by another process that names the tool (Amcache, Prefetch, BAM) is Windows reacting to its start.

The registry
After the clean shutdown of each run, the disk's hives — SYSTEM, SOFTWARE, SAM, SECURITY, DEFAULT, Amcache, the profiles' — are read offline, the machine off, and set key by key and value by value against those of the frozen image. It is the independent count of what Sysmon gives the processes. The system volume, encrypted by BitLocker without a protector, is opened by its clear key.

The control
A run that starts nothing (`ver`) measures the launcher and Windows' own activity; what it shows too is not charged to the tool.

The deferred
The ShimCache is only written at shutdown: every run ends with a clean shutdown, a restart and its reading.

5.2 What each one leaves

Tool	Files written on C:	Registry written	Windows' reactions
WAC (collection)	none	none	Amcache: one entry during the run; ShimCache: one entry at shutdown
KAPE, targets	none	4 `ZoneMap` values of Internet Settings in the user's hive; 115 creation opens (certificate stores, policies)	Amcache and ShimCache for `kape.exe`
KAPE, targets and modules	28: 14 in `ProgramData\Microsoft\NetFramework\BreadcrumbStore`, 14 in the user's Temp (`system-commandline-sentinel-files`)	the same 4 values, rewritten by 14 processes (136 writes); 8 RAS tracing keys created by 4 tools (56 values); 126 creation opens	Amcache and ShimCache for KAPE and 14 tools; the key's partition table rewritten in USBSTOR
EZ tools, live	none	no value; 4 creation opens (policies, `Tcpip`, `Internet Settings`)	Amcache and ShimCache for the 6 tools

The hives read offline confirm it. Beyond what the control run changes too, they change during every run — from 59 keys and values for KAPE to 311 for WAC, whose collection lasts 15 minutes —, but only the writes Sysmon gives the tool's processes are the tool's: for WAC, none; the rest is Windows' activity in the measuring window (WaaSMedic, Defender, scheduled tasks, WMI, Windows Update, OneDrive, Explorer), unrelated to the tool, and the Amcache entry of each executable started. The RAS tracing keys of KAPE's modules appear added, as Sysmon gives them.

The tools' processes had no event written in Windows' own logs (System, Security, Application, operational logs): those of the measuring window are the services' logons, Defender, group policy, the Microsoft account, the telemetry, shared with the control run or other processes. Process creation auditing is not on in the clone; on, it would have recorded a 4688 and a 4689 per process (chapter 9).

The monitoring installed, on the other hand, records each tool's run: the Sysmon log received, for the tool's processes only,

Tool	Processes	Raw reads	Files created	Processes opened
WAC	1	3	25,532, all on the key; 777 deleted on the key	128 with limited query (0x1000), 42 with query and memory read (0x1410)
KAPE, targets	1	2	2,940, all on the key	Defender, for synchronisation
KAPE, targets and modules	15	2	3,008 on the key, 28 on C:	its tools, with full access (17 opens); Defender, for synchronisation (18)
EZ tools, live	6	6	45, all on the key	Defender, for synchronisation (6)

plus the libraries each process loads (25 for WAC). An EDR draws the same telemetry from it, and may flag the raw reading of the volumes (`RawAccessRead`): WAC's are of C:, the EFI partition and the physical disk, for the boot sectors.

Processes opened
WAC reads the process list and their owners through Terminal Services, which opens each with limited query (0x1000), LSASS included; then, for each process's module list, it opens it with query and memory read (0x1410), with no write, thread or injection right. The protected processes (LSASS, services, Defender) refuse the latter. KAPE opens its own tools with full access to drive them.

Creation open
`RegCreateKeyEx` creates the key if it is missing and opens it otherwise; Sysmon does not tell the two apart. The .NET libraries open the certificate stores and the policy keys that way. A created key changes date; a key only opened does not.

The `ZoneMap` values
Written by WinINet's initialisation in every .NET process that loads it, they modify the examined user's `NTUSER.DAT` hive, hence its log and the key's date.

The RAS tracing keys
Loading the remote access libraries (`rasapi32.dll`) creates, for each program, two keys under `HKLM\SOFTWARE\Microsoft\Tracing`: EvtxECmd, MFTECmd, RECmd and SrumECmd started by KAPE left eight of them in SOFTWARE.

The .NET files
The runtime leaves a "breadcrumb" per loaded assembly in `BreadcrumbStore`, and the System.CommandLine library a file per tool in the user's Temp. Started on their own, the EZ tools left none; started by KAPE, they did.

Prefetch and BAM
None of the programs started from the USB key received a Prefetch file or a BAM value, while `cmd.exe`, started from the system disk by the same task, has its BAM value. A tool copied onto the machine and started from there would receive some.

The .NET prerequisite

KAPE and the EZ tools need the .NET 9 runtime, present on the clone. On a machine without it, installing it writes hundreds of files and keys; WAC is a self-contained executable.

5.3 What the measure corrected in WAC

WAC cleared the screen at start-up with `system("cls")`, which starts `cmd.exe`: a process created on the examined machine and the Prefetch of `CMD.EXE` updated, at every collection. The screen is now cleared through the console API, WAC no longer imports any function able to start a process, and the build script refuses a version that would import one.

The measure of 29 October 2026 showed a second trace: to list each process's modules, the Toolhelp snapshot (`CreateToolhelp32Snapshot`) itself opened 42 processes of the session with full access (`PROCESS_ALL_ACCESS`, 0x1FFFFF), the very pattern an EDR watches for. WAC now opens each process with query and memory-read rights only, and reads its modules through psapi; measured again on 30 October, no full-access open is left.

> **Key point**
>
> Every trace of WAC is explained: it starts no process, writes no file on the machine, no registry value, no event in Windows' logs. What remains are the traces Windows leaves of any program started — one Amcache entry, one ShimCache entry at shutdown —, and what the monitoring in place records of its run (Sysmon, process creation auditing, EDR): unavoidable, and described in the harmlessness file.

CHAPTER 6

Accuracy

6.1 In favour of WAC

Hive logs replayed in order
The `.LOG1` and `.LOG2` logs keep, behind the recent entries, leftovers of an earlier generation. RECmd applies them in file order, hence after the newer ones. It thus rolls hives back to an older state: 34 last BAM executions older than the hive's, the test account's last logon and the two USB keys' last connection from before the day's boot, UserAssist counters behind (measured on 29 October 2026). WAC sorts the entries by sequence and stops at the break in the chain. The logs themselves confirm it, Marvin32 digests included.

Events of cleared logs
A cleared log keeps its records: WAC reads them again and flags them `EvtRecovered`, never presenting them as live; EvtxECmd does not see them.

Event values as Windows renders them
Hexadecimal `0x3e7`, GUIDs in braces, booleans `true`, binary `69060000`, dates with their `Z`, U+200E marks kept: the forms Event Viewer shows and one searches for. EvtxECmd changes nine of them, and is wrong on 25 values, such as a boolean `False` that Windows renders `true`; each one is settled by the XML Windows renders (`Get-WinEvent`) from the same log.

Nothing invented
A value absent from the source is not emitted. AmcacheParser writes 5,500 default values absent from the hive (`IsPeFile: False` for a PE executable), SrumECmd 18,412 (0 or -1).

Partial Amcache SHA-1 flagged
For a file larger than 30 MiB, Amcache hashes only the first 31,457,280 bytes (measured on `mrt.exe`). WAC says so (`AmcacheSha1CoversBytes`); without it, comparing with the whole file's SHA-1 would wrongly conclude to a modification.

No misleading field
The ShimCache "executed" flag, which AppCompatCacheParser gives, says "no" for 105 of the 117 binaries that Prefetch proves were run. WAC does not collect it: that "no" would lead to conclude a program never ran.

Precision to 100 ns
WAC gives every date at its source's precision. By default, PECmd, LECmd and SrumECmd round to the second, and LECmd ignores `--mp` in its CSV.

Dated local time
Every date is given in UTC and in the suspect's local time, with the offset in force at that date. The EZ tools give UTC only, without saying so by a `Z`.

Others' readings checked
SBECmd's "FirstInteracted" and "LastInteracted", RECmd's "CreatedOn" of an account, are readings of key write times. WAC publishes those times themselves: anyone can draw their own reading from them, without inheriting a ready-made one. SBECmd also gives a wrong `NodeSlot` (0) to first-level folders.

SrumECmd's ESE reading errors
8 energy rows out of 2,306 carry the content of the row before; dissect.esedb sides with WAC.

ESE database not closed cleanly
A SRUM database taken from a running machine may not be closed cleanly. SrumECmd stopped on one of them (measured on 9 October 2026); WAC replays its logs on the working copy (`esent.dll`), then reads it.

Deleted accounts
The bench deletes an account (`wacrdp`) after using it. RECmd still lists it, from a SAM rolled back to an earlier state; WAC does not give it, and neither does `Get-LocalUser`.

Collection
Each WAC exhibit carries MD5, SHA-1 and SHA-256, the eight NTFS dates of its original and its MFT entry, in a sealed manifest. KAPE gives one SHA-1 and three dates.

6.2 In favour of the EZ tools

Coverage
No gap is left open. The keys of the Kroll batch WAC ignored are now read: installed programs, Defender exclusions, RecentDocs, MountPoints2, known networks, the event log configuration, among others. Those that trace no activity are left out, with their reason. The files KapeTriage alone took are collected and converted: Chromium browsers, WebCache and INetCache, the tabs open or closed, the favicons, the address bar's predictor, the Windows timeline, shortcuts outside Recent, the Default profile's hive, `$Secure:$SDS`, `$Boot`, Defender's WPP traces and the DPAPI master keys. Only the `desktop.ini` files are left out, of no investigative value.

Speed on small artefacts
Taken one by one, Prefetch, Amcache and shortcuts decode faster with the EZ tool: see chapter 3.

Ready-to-read interpretations
The EZ tools split and name some fields: executable, date and description of a SRUM application, known folder names, a file's extension. WAC gives the raw value, as Windows stores it.

> **Limit**
> What KAPE takes and WAC does not is mostly application files in the profiles (chapter 4). They match no artefact WAC decodes: their worth depends on the investigation.

CHAPTER 7

Output formats

7.1 What each tool writes

Tool	Formats	Note
AmcacheParser	CSV	8 files, one per table
AppCompatCacheParser	CSV	
RBCmd	CSV	
SrumECmd	CSV	7 files
EvtxECmd	CSV, JSON, XML	
JLECmd	CSV, JSON, HTML	
LECmd	CSV, JSON, HTML, XML	
MFTECmd	CSV, JSON, bodyfile	
PECmd	CSV, JSON, HTML	
RECmd	CSV, JSON	plus one CSV per plugin
SBECmd	CSV, JSON	
KAPE	copy of the files, CSV copy log	
WAC	JSON for every artefact	one file per artefact, plus the sealed manifest

7.2 What sets them apart

Four tools out of eleven write CSV only. In the others, the JSON transcribes the CSV line: one text line per record (JSON Lines), flat.

Types
In the EZ tools, numbers are strings: a run count is written `"RunCount":"458"`, a record number `"EventRecordId":"21572"`. WAC writes numbers, booleans, strings.

Structures
In the EZ tools, a list becomes a comma-joined string (the files a Prefetch loaded, its directories), and an event's data are JSON escaped *inside* a string (`Payload`), to decode a second time. WAC nests: a Prefetch's volumes and their directories, a shortcut's items, an event's `Name`/`Value` pairs.

Dates
In the EZ tools, UTC is not flagged (`2026-09-30 23:04:46`) and precision depends on an option. WAC gives full ISO 8601, in UTC (…`Z`) and in local time with its offset (…`+02:00`).

Missing value
The EZ tools write a default value, or an empty cell. WAC omits the field; an artefact not collected is declared so (`NotRequested`, `NotCollected`), so that an empty list is not taken for an absence of traces.

Provenance
WAC's manifest ties every value to the exhibit it comes from, with its hashes and original dates.

Console
The EZ tools detail their work on the console; some write the decoding itself there when no file is asked for. WAC writes only its progress there: everything it finds is in the files.

> **Key point**
> For an analyst, the difference shows at the first processing: a WAC JSON loads as it is into an analysis tool or into WAE, with nothing to split again; an EZ output is handled like a spreadsheet, whose numbers must be converted back, lists split again and event data decoded again.

CHAPTER 8

What the confrontation taught WAC

Each defect below produced a valid JSON that was wrong, or incomplete. All are fixed, with a check that would have caught them.

Artefact	Defect fixed
$MFT	stale extension records merged with the base
EVTX	floats cut to 6 digits; binary as “69 06 00 00”; hexadecimal integers and GUIDs in the wrong form; ProcessingErrorData ignored (21 events without data); events of cleared logs not read
Shortcuts	URI glued to the block after it; reading 2 bytes off without an ID list; ExtraData blocks not read (machine, tracking); target size not read; null DROIDs emitted
Jump lists	open count and MRU rank not read; DestList format version 1 not supported; application name corrupted
Shellbags	folder lost with everything below it; the folder’s key time, rank and NodeSlot missing; “Home” folder without a name; the `NTUSER.DAT` tree not read (only `UsrClass.dat`’s was)
Amcache	2 tables out of 14 and 4 to 6 values read: no SHA-1, size, driver or device; a SHA-1 named `Sha1`, read as the whole file’s, renamed `AmcacheSha1`
ShimCache	tabs of packaged applications replaced by spaces
SRUM	FILETIME dates left as numbers; UTF-16 text read as ANSI
Known identifiers	105 DLL paths of the GUID table (253 occurrences) whose generation had taken `\n` or `\r` for a line break: `system32\ netcorehc.dll` became `system32 etcorehc.dll`
Registry	BAM limited to accounts with a profile (a deleted account lost its executions); UserAssist foreground time not read
Collection	exhibits whose path passes 260 characters once in the store not written (482 on the full kit): now written in the extended form
Start-up	`system("cls")` started `cmd.exe` on the examined machine (traces measure)
Processes	each process’s module list, through the Toolhelp snapshot, had 42 processes opened with full access (traces measure): now opened with query and memory read only

Artefact	Defect fixed
Test harness	a crashing check silently stopped every following one; the EZ tools ran on the sealed exhibit store itself — SrumECmd wrote into it and WAC refused the next conversion; they now read a copy; LECmd set against the shortcuts of Recent alone, SRUM's PushNotifications table never paired

CHAPTER 9

Limits of the comparison

- One machine, virtual, running Windows 11: some artefacts are few there (2 USB keys, one Explorer search). The formats are the same on a real machine, but not every rare case is represented.
- The two collections follow each other instead of being simultaneous: the files written between them ($MFT, logs, Prefetch) rightly differ.
- The EZ tools ran with their maximum precision options; by default, they lose more.
- The times come from a virtual machine and its disk: they compare the tools with each other, they do not predict the time on a real machine, where the number of executables and the disk's speed weigh most.
- The traces are measured on a clone without network, one run per tool: a write of Windows the control run did not show is not laid on the tool unless Sysmon gives it to one of its processes; it stays listed as not attributed in `footprint-diff.py`'s results.
- Process creation auditing (Security 4688) is not active on the test machine: where it is, every tool leaves an event per process — one for WAC, fifteen for KAPE and its modules.
- The comparison covers the common artefacts. What only one tool reads has no reference here: its accuracy rests on the checks of the validation report.